

THE OPENING MANUAL

THE FIRST THREE TRACKS.

What the science says about how a crowd remembers a set, what four working DJs actually do to plan their openings, and the four moves that separate a memorable opening from a forgettable one.

WHAT'S IN THIS MANUAL

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This is a working craft guide, not prescriptive advice. Every gig is different. Every room is different. Use these frameworks to think about your openings — then trust your ears.

01 · THE SCIENCE

WHY THE OPENING IS WHAT THEY REMEMBER.

Cognitive psychology has been studying how humans remember sequences of events for over 60 years. One of the most robust findings is called the serial position effect — or, more commonly, the primacy and recency effects.

Human memory doesn't record experience evenly. It records the START and the END.

The middle gets compressed, blurred, forgotten. This has been replicated across hundreds of studies since Murdock's original 1962 paper. It applies to lists of words, sequences of images, timelines of events — and, as any working DJ can tell you, DJ sets.

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR A DJ SET

The peak of your set — the drop everyone talks about — is the MIDDLE.

The first three tracks and the closing tracks are the EDGES.

Which means: the peak isn't what the crowd walks out remembering.

The opening is.

THE UNCOMFORTABLE TRUTH

Most DJs plan the peak in obsessive detail — the exact track, the exact drop, the exact timing. And then improvise the opening. This is exactly backwards. The primacy effect doesn't care that you played a legendary drop at 1am. If your first three tracks were forgettable, the whole night gets remembered as forgettable.

The best DJs in the world know this instinctively. That's why every one of them prepares the opening more than any other part of the set.

Source: Murdock, B.B. (1962). The serial position effect of free recall.

Journal of Experimental Psychology, 64(5), 482–488. Ongoing replication across cognitive psychology.

02 · WHAT WORKING DJS DO

FOUR DJS.

FOUR OPENING HABITS.

In August 2026, Pioneer DJ interviewed seven touring DJs about how they select their opening tracks. What's striking isn't the differences — it's what they all share: obsessive preparation of the opening, and radical adaptability at the last moment. Four of them below.

HEDEX

@hedexuk

OBSESSIVE OPENER PLANNING

"I really obsess and definitely overthink how I open the world that the crowd will be in for the next 60 minutes."

PURPLE DISCO MACHINE

@purple_disco_machine

CUSTOM INTRO PER VENUE

always start with my own intro — it gives the audience a brief pause before the music really kicks in."

ALEX FARELL

@alexfarelldj

MULTIPLE OPENERS READY

"I'll usually have about 10 opening tunes that I can use depending on how the crowd is reacting to the DJ before me."

ALYCIA BEZGO

@alyciabezgo

LAST-MOMENT DECISION

"I always decide on the opening track at the very last moment. Every event is different, every crowd has its own character."

THE PATTERN ACROSS ALL FOUR

They arrive at the venue with multiple opening options prepared. They read the room before they play. And they decide the actual first track late — sometimes at the very last second.

Source: "How do you begin your DJ sets?" — Pioneer DJ, August 2026.

03 · THE THREE-TRACK FRAMEWORK

THE THREE JOBS.

Every opening track is doing a specific psychological job. Plan them like this.

01 THE INTRODUCTION

Sets the palette. Signals you're present.

This track isn't a statement of who you are. It's a signal that you're here, paying attention, and offering the room something specific. It sets the tempo, the sonic world, the mood.

PICK Tempo, sonic palette, mood you're offering

02 THE PROPOSITION

Confirms track 1 wasn't an accident.

The room is now paying attention. Track 2 confirms your first choice wasn't random. It reveals real information about your taste. Expectations start forming here.

PICK Coherence with Track 1, first taste signal

03 THE COMMITMENT

The room decides. Trust or leave.

This is the pivot. Track 3 is where the room decides whether to trust the next 90 minutes to you.

Get it right and they settle in. Get it wrong and they check their phones.

PICK Peak preparation of the opening — plan this hardest

THE RULE OF ATTENTION

Give Track 3 the same preparation time you give your peak track. It's that important.

04 · THE OPENING PLANNING WORKSHEET

PLAN YOUR NEXT OPENING.

Fill this in before your next gig. Print it, note it in Rekordbox, or keep it in your phone. The point is to decide the shape of the opening before you're in the booth.

CONTEXT

Venue / gig: _____
e.g. Bandra warehouse, 400 cap, warm-up slot

Your slot: _____
e.g. Opener 10pm-12am / Peak time / Closer

Who plays before you: _____
and what they typically end on

Who plays after you: _____
and what they typically open with

Room mood you expect: _____
e.g. building, tired, chatty, focused

YOUR THREE-TRACK OPENING

01 THE INTRODUCTION (option + backup)

- Primary: _____
- Backup (if room is quieter than expected): _____

02 THE PROPOSITION (option + backup)

- Primary: _____
- Backup: _____

03 THE COMMITMENT (plan hardest)

- Primary: _____
- Why this specific track for this room: _____

5-10 MINUTES BEFORE YOUR SET

Go to the floor. Watch the room. Which of your two intro options fits? Note it here: _____

05 · THE AUDIT WORKSHEET · 06 · OPENERS BY CONTEXT

FIX THE OPENING YOU'VE BEEN PLAYING.

Audit your last five sets. If you can't answer these questions, that's the problem you're solving.

01 What were the first three tracks of your last five sets?

02 Which of those five openings was the strongest — and specifically why?

03 How much time did you spend planning the peak vs. the opening?

04 Did you arrive 5-10 minutes early to read the room before playing?

05 If a listener from last week described your opening, what would they say?

06 Which track was your Track 3 (the commitment) in your last set — and did the room respond?

06 · OPENERS BY CONTEXT

A quick reference framework. Not exhaustive — a starting point to think in.

WARM-UP SLOT (empty room)

Low tempo, atmospheric, groove-led. Nothing that demands attention.
Goal: create a room worth arriving to.

OPENER (pre-peak, room filling)

Mid-tempo, warm palette. Some texture. Building without pushing.
Goal: earn trust so they stay through your peak.

PEAK TIME (following another DJ)

Match the DJ before you for 1-2 tracks, then steer to your sound.
Goal: continuity + gradual takeover.

CLOSER (room committed)

Emotional, memorable, the tracks you want them leaving thinking about.
Goal: primacy AND recency working for you.

THE CLOSE

**THE PEAK IS
THE STORY YOU TELL
YOURSELF.**

**THE FIRST THREE
TRACKS ARE THE STORY
THEY TELL.**

You back up every set.
You insure your controller.
You protect your ears.
You protect the body that carries all of it.

Now plan the opening it all rests on.

THE REST OF THE SERIES

No.01 INSURE · Health insurance for working DJs
No.02 RATE · Pricing your work
No.03 TDS · Tax setup for Indian DJs
No.04 CONTRACT · The performance contract
No.05 EARS · Hearing protection
No.06 BRAIN · The neuroscience of DJing
No.07 MOMENTS · Music as memory
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